

Internet Instructors

With India emerging as a knowledge hub of sorts, we look at a successful, Indian-origins e-learning firm in the US, which provides coaching to school and college students

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Young Indian and far-east Asian students in the United States are sincere and hard-working, they pay their credit card bills in full each month, and they're very good at maths. There are some SAT and GRE statistics to validate that last point, but it is, ultimately, a stereotype. As it happens, it's a very popular one: Americans seem to genuinely believe that this demographic is "smart," as they put it. A rather nice image to possess, actually. It doesn't hurt.

In fact, it seems to have helped the cause of TutorVista (www.TutorVista.com), an online tutoring and test-prep company founded in Bangalore and brought to the United States in late 2005—services are now also offered in Britain. They provide one-on-one coaching to K12 and college students, both undergraduate and graduate, in a variety of subjects, and charge considerably less than the competition—in effect making such instruction that much less of a luxury. That's "bachelors level" and "post-graduate level" in Indian terms. "K12" refers to Kindergarten through to the 12th standard in Indian terms.

It can't have been easy for an Indian firm to have achieved a credible position in the US market. But the stereotype helped.

Ask Krishnan Ganesh, founder, chairman, and CEO. His team's initial research in the US—without which they wouldn't have spent "a single dollar" on the project—gave them the go-ahead because of "the 'nerdy' image and success of Indians in the school and college education system in the US."

Desirables

Going beyond what helped and what didn't, what makes for good e-learning at the K12 and college levels? First and most important, tutors must be competent and well-trained, and sensitive to students' needs. Which leads to point number two: one-on-one coaching is immensely desirable. Even outside of e-learning, it's always been sought-after by parents, and it's traditionally expensive. With the Internet, as Ganesh and co. have proved, it need not be, and that's #3—affordability. Then, the interface and session scheduling should be student-friendly. And last but not least, when you cut across continents, student and teacher understanding each other becomes an issue, small or big.

